

SECURING ECHONET LITE PROTOCOL FOR SMART HOME IOT DEVICES

MUHAMMAD SUHAIB

UNIVERSITI SAINS MALAYSIA

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SECURING ECHONET LITE PROTOCOL FOR SMART HOME IOT DEVICES

by

MUHAMMAD SUHAIB

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

Many thanks to Prof. Donald Knuth for giving us $\text{\TeX}$, and Leslie Lamport for $\text{\LaTeX}$.

I first learned $\text{\LaTeX}$ as an undergraduate student in Computer Science at the University of Warwick. Back in Malaysia, I picked it up again while doing my M.Sc. at USM, as part of some productive procrastination (there I've admitted it!!). This coincided with Dr. Dhanesh's and Dr. Azman's efforts in raising awareness about $\text{\LaTeX}$ at USM during NaCSPC'05 – somehow one thing led to another, and I now conduct trainings and consultations on $\text{\LaTeX}$. ☺

Since then, many friends and fellow $\text{\LaTeX}$ users have given feedback and helped relayed important updates from IPS to me, to help improve the class and template. It has actually come to a point where you are too numerous to name! Thank you all, as well as everyone who has attended my talks and workshops, used my various templates, downloaded examples from my website (<http://liantze.penguinattack.org/latextypesetting.html>).

Hope everyone graduates quickly then!

Joseph Ooi: Many thanks to LianTze Lim and wnarffin for maintaining the GitHub repo which contains the $\text{\LaTeX}$ template, without which my attempt at reproducing the likeness of the latest thesis template version from USM would be unachievable. Here's to hoping more people taste the forbidden fruit that is $\text{\LaTeX}$ and forsake Microsoft Office Word. Happy $\text{\LaTeX}$ -ing everyone!

Joseph Ooi: By the way, don't worry about if warnings that the hyper reference to some of your defined acronyms not being defined pop up. They should go away once you use those acronyms via `\ac{...}` or `\acs{...}` or `\acf{...}` or something else at least once in your text. Or you can just ignore them.

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LIST OF SYMBOLS

$\lim$	limit
θ	angle in radians

LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

IPS	Institut Pengajian Siswazah
PPSK	Pusat Pengajian Sains Komputer
USM	Universiti Sains Malaysia
UTMK	Unit Terjemahan Melalui Komputer
SYDUUCF	Something You Don't Usually Use Capitalization For

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**PENGAMANAN PROTOKOL ECHONET LITE UNTUK PERANTI IOT
RUMAH PINTAR**

ABSTRAK

Ini merupakan abstrak Melayu untuk tesis USM. Ianya disediakan dengan sistem penyediaan dokumen L^AT_EX.

SECURING ECHONET LITE PROTOCOL FOR SMART HOME IOT DEVICES

ABSTRACT

This is the English abstract of a USM thesis. It was prepared with the $\text{\LaTeX}$ document typesetting system.

CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

This chapter, divided into thirteen sections, introduces the research problem and situates it within the broader evolution of residential energy management and smart home communication security. Section 1.1 traces the transition from centralized Smart Grid infrastructure to Machine-to-Machine (M2M) enabled smart home networks and classifies domestic communication protocols across the OSI model. Section 1.2 presents a detailed technical overview of the ECHONET Lite protocol, its frame structure, and its native security posture. Section 1.3 analyzes the cybersecurity threat landscape confronting smart home networks and taxonomizes the principal attack vectors relevant to this study. Sections 1.4 and 1.5 articulate the research motivation and problem statement, respectively, while Section 1.5 additionally derives a set of formal research questions. Section 1.6 enumerates the research objectives, and Section 1.7 defines the scope, boundaries, and underlying assumptions of the study. Section 1.8 discusses the theoretical and practical contributions of this thesis, and Section 1.9 outlines the five-phase research roadmap adopted to achieve the stated objectives. Section 1.10 presents the organization of the remaining chapters, Section 1.11 discusses the academic and industrial significance of the study, Section 1.12 defines key terms used throughout the thesis, and Section 1.13 closes the chapter with a concise summary.

1.1 Overview

The global energy ecosystem is undergoing a fundamental structural transition toward the Smart Grid era and next-generation energy management frameworks. Driven by national decarbonization goals, fluctuating energy costs, and the need for peak-load balancing, traditional centralized generation networks are being replaced by automated Demand-Side Management (DSM) architectures. Within this ecosystem, Home Energy Management Systems (HEMS) serve as the primary coordination hubs connecting the utility grid to the residential domain. HEMS platforms dynamically optimize household

power consumption by interacting directly with distributed energy resources (DERs) such as solar inverters, electric vehicle (EV) chargers, battery storage units, and major residential appliances.

Historically, electricity distribution followed a strictly unidirectional model: bulk power was generated at centralized plants, stepped up for transmission, and delivered to passive residential consumers with no feedback path other than periodic metering. The Smart Grid paradigm inverts this relationship by embedding bidirectional communication, distributed sensing, and automated control throughout the distribution network, allowing utilities and consumers to jointly participate in load balancing, dynamic pricing response, and renewable energy integration. As distributed generation and storage assets have proliferated at the household level, the locus of intelligent control has progressively shifted from the utility substation to the consumer premises, giving rise to HEMS as the residential counterpart of utility-scale Energy Management Systems (EMS). This evolutionary trajectory, from centralized generation to distributed, consumer-centric orchestration, is the structural backdrop against which the security of residential M2M messaging must be understood.

The operational success of HEMS relies on the rapid proliferation of interconnected Consumer Internet of Things (IoT) nodes and domestic appliance infrastructure. Residential devices are no longer passive electrical loads; they operate as autonomous, energy-aware nodes capable of real-time telemetry reporting and automated load shedding. Machine-to-Machine (M2M) communication protocols form the foundational layer of this residential ecosystem, enabling seamless interoperability between heterogeneous edge appliances and central home gateways over local IP networks. Unlike enterprise or industrial M2M deployments, which typically operate within professionally managed and monitored network perimeters, domestic M2M ecosystems are provisioned, configured, and maintained largely by non-expert end users, over consumer-grade routers, and alongside untrusted general-purpose devices sharing the same local area network. This distinction is significant from a security standpoint: the same prop-

erties that make smart home M2M networks convenient and low-cost, plug-and-play discovery, minimal configuration overhead, and lightweight messaging, also reduce the opportunity for centralized security governance that is typical of enterprise or industrial control networks.

However, the hyper-connectivity of domestic M2M networks significantly expands the residential attack surface. Compromised local networks or rogue edge nodes introduce severe operational threats, as malicious command injection can disrupt device operations or cause artificial power spikes across local distribution networks. Protecting application-layer messaging within smart home environments is therefore essential to preserving consumer privacy, physical asset integrity, and grid reliability. Because HEMS gateways aggregate telemetry from, and issue control commands to, multiple appliances simultaneously, a single compromised message exchange can cascade into coordinated, multi-device disruption, an effect with no direct analogue in traditional single-appliance fault scenarios.

The urgency of securing residential M2M messaging is not speculative; it is grounded in a well-documented and rapidly worsening global cyber-threat trajectory. Cybersecurity Ventures estimated that worldwide cybercrime losses grew from approximately USD 3 trillion in 2015 to USD 6 trillion in 2021, and forecast that damages would reach USD 10.5 trillion annually by 2025, a growth rate of roughly 15 percent per year that would make cybercrime, if measured as an economy, larger than that of most nations (Morgan, 2020). Table 1.0 summarizes this trajectory to illustrate the scale and pace of the threat that motivates protective research at every layer of connected infrastructure, including the residential domain addressed by this thesis.

Table 1.0 Growth Trajectory of Global Cybercrime Costs
Year Estimated Global Cybercrime Cost (USD)
2015 3 trillion 2021 6 trillion 2025 (projected) 10.5 trillion
Source: Adapted from Cybersecurity Ventures (Morgan, 2020).

Connected consumer and IoT devices, the same class of edge nodes that HEMS platforms rely upon, have historically been at the center of some of the most damaging cyber-incidents on record, rather than a marginal or theoretical risk category. The Mirai botnet, first identified in August 2016, propagated by scanning the internet for IoT devices, including home routers, IP cameras, and other consumer-grade appliances, still configured with factory-default credentials, and enlisting them into a botnet capable of launching massive distributed denial-of-service (DDoS) attacks (Antonakakis et al., 2017). In September 2016, a Mirai-driven attack struck the Krebs on Security website at a then-record 620 Gbit/s, and the following month a coordinated Mirai attack against the Dyn DNS provider rendered major internet services, including Twitter, Netflix, Reddit, and GitHub, inaccessible across large parts of the United States and Europe (Antonakakis et al., 2017; Fruhlinger, 2018). Later that year, a related Mirai variant crashed approximately 900,000 consumer routers belonging to Deutsche Telekom customers through a failed exploitation attempt, causing widespread residential internet outages (Antonakakis et al., 2017). Rutgers University, targeted by Mirai-based DDoS attacks between 2014 and 2016, reportedly spent over USD 300,000 on incident consultation and increased its cybersecurity budget by a further USD 1 million in direct response, costs the university itself cited among its reasons for raising student tuition and fees the following year (Antonakakis et al., 2017). Critically, the threat posed by compromised consumer devices has not receded with time; it has intensified. A resurgent Mirai-based botnet, publicly identified in 2024 and comprising an estimated 300,000 or more compromised consumer devices, has continued to set new records for attack scale, including a 31.4 Tbps DDoS event recorded against Cloudflare infrastructure, underscoring that the aggregation of insecure, network-connected consumer devices remains an active and escalating global threat rather than a historical footnote (Antonakakis et al., 2017). These documented incidents demonstrate, with concrete financial and operational evidence, what can occur when large populations of under-secured, network-connected consumer devices are left without adequate origin authentication: services fail at national scale, institutions absorb unplanned costs in the hundreds of

thousands to millions of dollars, and the compromised devices themselves become instruments of harm against third parties. HEMS-integrated appliances communicating over ECHONET Lite occupy precisely this same at-risk device category, sharing direct network reachability, constrained processing resources, and, in the absence of the mechanism proposed in this thesis, an identical lack of native origin authentication. The difference is one of consequence rather than likelihood: where a compromised router or camera primarily threatens network availability, a compromised HEMS appliance can directly manipulate physical energy loads, elevating the stakes from service disruption to potential physical and grid-level harm. This precedent of demonstrated, quantifiable loss from unauthenticated consumer devices is precisely what justifies the application-layer authentication mechanism developed in this thesis.

1.2 ECHONET Lite Protocol: An Overview

Established by the ECHONET Consortium and recognized under ISO/IEC 14543-4-3, the ECHONET Lite protocol specification defines standard communication for smart home appliances and HEMS devices. Enforced across international markets and widely adopted in residential deployments, ECHONET Lite normalizes multi-vendor interoperability across more than 100 device classes, including HVAC units, smart meters, heat pump water heaters, and photovoltaic arrays.

ECHONET Lite occupies a distinctive position among smart home messaging standards because it was developed specifically with energy management semantics at its core, rather than as a general-purpose IoT messaging layer later adapted for energy use cases. Its object-oriented device model, in which every appliance class exposes a standardized set of properties (e.g., operational status, power consumption, set-point temperature), allows HEMS controllers to interoperate with appliances from different manufacturers without bespoke integration work. This device-class standardization has made ECHONET Lite the de facto messaging backbone for HEMS certification programs in several national smart grid initiatives, embedding it deeply into residential energy policy infrastructure rather than treating it as an optional convenience layer. The

protocol’s continued longevity, despite the emergence of newer general-purpose smart home standards such as Matter, is attributable to this entrenched role in energy-sector certification and the substantial installed base of already-deployed HEMS-compliant appliances.

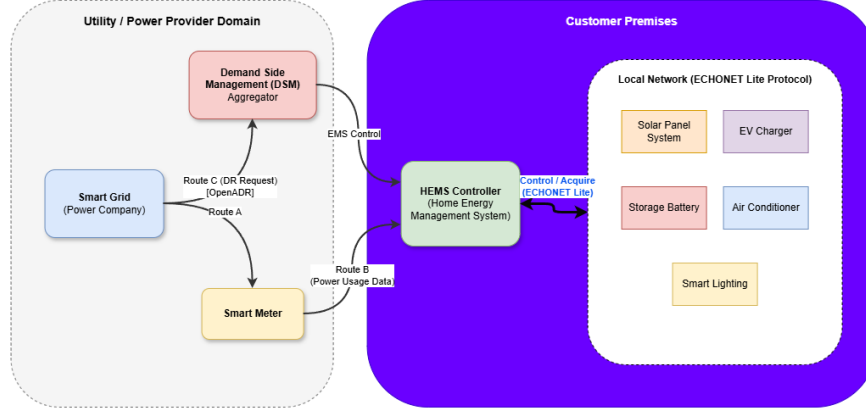


Figure 1.1: Echonet Lite Architecture.

ECHONET Lite uses an object-property-action model to govern device behavior. Devices send read, write, or notification requests (Get, Set, SNA) over unicast or multi-cast IP channels. The ESV command code field, in particular, determines the semantic intent of a frame (e.g., ‘0x62’ for a property read request, ‘0x61’ for a property write request, ‘0x73’ for an unsolicited property notification), and it is precisely this field, together with the EDT payload it governs, that an attacker targets when attempting unauthorized command injection or replay. Because the SEOJ/DEOJ addressing scheme identifies devices purely by class and instance codes rather than by any cryptographically verifiable identity, any node capable of observing or injecting traffic on the local network segment can construct a syntactically valid ECHONET Lite frame addressed to any other device on that segment.

Despite its widespread structural adoption, standard ECHONET Lite transmits plaintext binary frames without mandatory application-layer cryptographic encipherment or dynamic origin authentication. Designed originally for physically closed, trusted home networks, native ECHONET Lite frames lack fields for data confidentiality, frame integrity, or sender identity verification. Wrapping ECHONET Lite in

heavy lower-layer transport security protocols (such as DTLS or TLS) often introduces excessive processing overhead, memory footprint expansion, and latency spikes on resource-constrained 8-bit or 16-bit appliance microcontrollers. In practice, this leaves implementers with an unappealing binary choice: ship devices with no meaningful application-layer protection, or absorb the disproportionate computational cost of a full transport-security handshake on hardware that was never provisioned with that overhead in mind. This unresolved tension between security completeness and embedded resource constraints is the central technical gap that motivates the present research.

1.3 Smart-Home Networks and Cybersecurity Threats

The local home network is an important trust boundary for ECHONET Lite communication. The protocol can be used within a smart-home environment, but network reachability does not by itself prove that a sender is authorized. This distinction is particularly important when a HEMS controls appliances remotely or when a local network includes devices with different security capabilities. A secure end-to-end remote-control system for ECHONET Lite appliances has been investigated in previous work, illustrating that remote access and appliance control require explicit security design (tanakaEvaluationSecureEndtoend2018).

This thesis considers three threat classes at the application layer. A replay attack reuses a previously valid command. An injection attack creates or modifies a command so that a receiver performs an unauthorized operation. A denial-of-service attack attempts to prevent legitimate communication by consuming processing, communication, or device resources. These threats are analysed as security requirements for the proposed mechanism; this chapter does not claim a measured prevalence of any threat without a supporting empirical source.

1.4 Research Motivation

The motivation for this research is the gap between the lightweight appliance communication model of ECHONET Lite and the security assurance required when that communication is exposed to an untrusted or remotely reachable network. An application-layer mechanism can make the security decision at the point where the ECHONET Lite message is parsed and interpreted.

The proposed direction is a frame-level extension that authenticates relevant message data, detects modification, and rejects commands that fail freshness or replay validation. Its usefulness must be assessed not only by security behaviour but also by the communication and processing overhead imposed on constrained appliance nodes.

1.5 Problem Statement

This study addresses the following problem: standard ECHONET Lite communication provides an application-level data model for home appliances, but the standard frame does not by itself provide the message authentication, integrity verification, and anti-replay controls required for communication across a potentially untrusted network (**echonet_lite_part2**). Without a mechanism that combines origin verification, message integrity, and freshness validation, an attacker who gains access to the communication path may attempt unauthorized command injection or replay.

1.6 Research Objectives

The objectives of this research are to achieve the following:

1. To propose a frame-level security mechanism for ECHONET Lite that provides message authentication and data integrity without changing the protocol's core object and property model.
2. To propose an anti-replay and temporal-validation mechanism within the security extension to reduce the risk of unauthorized command injection and duplicated

valid messages.

3. To evaluate the proposed mechanism in terms of security behavior and performance overhead, including its effect on latency and operational efficiency relative to standard ECHONET Lite communication.

1.7 Scope and Limitations

The study is limited to application-layer protection for ECHONET Lite messages. It focuses on message authentication, data integrity, freshness or replay validation, and the processing overhead associated with the proposed extension. It does not claim to solve every security problem in a smart grid or smart home. Physical-layer attacks, radio interference, appliance hardware tampering, general-purpose public-key infrastructure, and the security of unrelated smart-home protocols are outside the primary scope unless required for comparison.

The evaluation results will be bounded by the selected simulation, emulation, or hardware environment. Results obtained from that environment should therefore be interpreted as evidence about the tested implementation and workload, rather than as universal performance values for every ECHONET Lite appliance.

1.8 Research Contribution

The intended contribution is an application-layer security extension for ECHONET Lite that connects protocol-level message processing with authentication, integrity, and replay validation requirements. A second contribution is an implementation and evaluation procedure that makes the overhead of the extension observable. Contribution claims will be finalized only after the design and evaluation results have been reported; design features or performance values are not presented here as empirical findings.

1.9 Research Steps

The research follows five stages. First, the ECHONET Lite message model and relevant threats are analysed to derive security and performance requirements. Second, the authentication and freshness mechanism is designed. Third, the mechanism is implemented and integrated with a standard ECHONET Lite communication path. Fourth, legitimate and adversarial message exchanges are tested in the selected evaluation environment. Finally, the results are analysed using the defined security and performance measures.

1.10 Thesis Organization

Chapter ?? reviews ECHONET Lite, smart-home communication, and relevant security mechanisms. Chapter ?? presents the requirements and design of the proposed extension. Chapter ?? describes its implementation and test environment. The discussion chapter interprets the evaluation results and considers limitations, while the conclusion summarizes the findings and identifies possible future work.

APPENDICES

APPENDIX A DATA USED

Put some test data here.

Joseph Ooi: You can still make sections and subsections as usual. This is essentially the same as you would do for chapters, but instead you **MUST USE** `\appchapter{...}`, **NOT** `\chapter{...}`. The rest are unchanged.

A.1 Example Appendix Section

A.1.1 Example Appendix Subsection

APPENDIX B UML DIAGRAMS

Yet another dummy placeholder for appendix material.

Joseph Ooi: Another reminder to **USE** `\appchapter{...}` for the appendix chapters, **DO NOT USE** `\chapter{...}`.